

Our [import risk analyses](#) are consistent with Australia's international biosecurity obligations. This includes our obligations under the:

- World Trade Organization (WTO) Agreement on the Application of Sanitary and Phytosanitary Measures (SPS Agreement)
- International Plant Protection Convention (IPPC)
- World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH)
- International Health Regulations of the World Health Organization (WHO).

The SPS Agreement

The basic obligations of the SPS Agreement are that SPS measures must:

- be based on a risk assessment appropriate to the circumstances or drawn from standards, guidelines and recommendations developed by WOAH or the IPPC
- only be applied to the extent necessary to protect human, animal or plant life or health
- be based on science
- not arbitrarily or unjustifiably discriminate between WTO members or be a disguised restriction on trade.

An SPS measure is applied to protect human, animal or plant life or health from the biosecurity risks arising from pests or diseases. They are also applied to limit associated economic and environmental impacts. SPS measures include any legislation, requirements or procedures developed for this purpose which may directly or indirectly affect international trade.

Notification obligations

Under the SPS Agreement, WTO members must notify other members of:

- proposed sanitary or phytosanitary regulations
- changes to existing regulations in cases where the changes are not consistent with international standards and may have a significant effect on trade of other WTO members.

International Plant Protection Convention (IPPC)

The IPPC is a multilateral treaty for cooperation in plant health and protection. It is part of the United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO). The IPPC protects plant health by establishing international phytosanitary standards.

The IPPC recognises the right of member countries to use phytosanitary measures to regulate imported goods. In turn, member countries must comply with IPPC obligations. These include principles of necessity, technical justification and transparency in regulating imported goods.

World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH)

WOAH is the WTO reference organisation for standards relating to animal health and diseases that spread between animals and people. WOAH updates its international standards as new scientific information becomes available.

International Health Regulations

The International Health Regulations (2005) (IHR) were established by the World Health Organization (WHO). The IHR provide an overarching legal framework that defines countries' rights and obligations in handling public health events and emergencies that have the potential to cross borders. The IHR also aim to avoid unnecessary interference with international traffic and trade. As a WHO member and a signatory to the IHR, Australia upholds the standards and values of the IHR in protecting public health.

Read more about the IHR on the [WHO website](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/risk-analysis/conducting-import-risk-analysis/international-obligations>